

Session 12: Love Your Enemy

Key Takeaways

- Jesus calls out a misinterpretation of the idea that hating enemies is in line with the Torah. The Torah calls for loving neighbors, yes, but also for loving the immigrant and showing kindness to enemies.
- The Greek word *teleios*, often translated as “perfect,” means to be “whole,” “complete,” and “fulfilling one’s purpose.”
- Jesus’ call to radical enemy love is an invitation to become more truly human, which is the path to becoming more like God.

Case Study 6: Loving Your Enemy

a 43 **You have heard that it was said,**

b “You shall **love** your **neighbor**

b and **hate** your **enemy**.”

a' 44 **But I say to you,**

b' **love** your **enemies**

b' and pray for those who persecute you,

45 **so that you may be children** of **your Father who is in the skies** ;

for he causes his sun to rise on the **evil** and the **good** ,

and he sends rain on the **righteous** and the **unrighteous** .

a 46 **For if** you **love** those who **love** you,

b **what** reward do you have?

c **Do not even** the tax collectors do the same?

a' 47 **And if** you greet only your brothers,

b' **what** more are you doing than others?

c' **Do not even** the nations do the same?

48 **Therefore you are to be whole/complete** ,

as **your Father in the skies** is **whole/complete** .

In many ways this is a pair with the previous teaching: If Jesus' followers are to reject personal retaliation and revenge, they are to practice love as a symbolic act. This shows the disciple's identity and sense of security is grounded in something other than their culture's system of honor, status, and possession.

Love Your Neighbor

Matthew 5:43, "Love your neighbor," is from Leviticus 19:18, which was programmatic for Jesus, as he cited it as part of his greatest command teaching in Matthew 22:37-40. (Notice he omits "as yourself". He takes this as axiomatic, that is, self-evident based on the axiom his listeners presumably all know.)

Leviticus 19:17-18 Instructor's Translation

You shall not hate your brother in your heart,
but you shall reprove-reprove him,
lest you incur sin because of him.
You shall not take vengeance or bear a grudge against the sons of your own people,
but you shall love your neighbor as yourself:
I am Yahweh.

Matthew 22:35-40 NASB

³⁵ One of them, a lawyer, asked him a question, testing him,
³⁶ "Teacher, which is the great commandment in the Law?"
³⁷ And he said to him, "'You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind.'
³⁸ This is the great and foremost commandment.
³⁹ The second is like it, '**You shall love your neighbor as yourself.**'
⁴⁰ On these two commandments depend the whole Law and the Prophets."

The second phrase, "but hate your enemy," shows that Jesus is doing more than just quoting Leviticus 19:18, but rather referring to how it has been popularly understood, an understanding which he will challenge.

"Neighbor" is a frequent term in the Torah for "fellow member of the covenant community." Leviticus 19:17-18 makes the restrictive sense of neighbor clear.

Leviticus 19:17-18 Instructor's Translation

You shall not hate **your brother** (אָחִיךָ) in your heart; you may surely reprove your **neighbor** (עֲמִיתְךָ), but shall not incur sin because of him. You shall not take vengeance, nor bear any grudge against **the sons of your people** (בְּנֵי עַמְּךָ), but you shall love **your neighbor** (לְרֵעֶךָ) as yourself; I am the Lord.

As it stands, the context of Leviticus 19:18 makes it clear that inter-Israelite relationships are in focus here.

The related question of the Israelites' attitude to non-Israelites is not raised in Leviticus 19:17-18, but later in the same chapter of Leviticus 19.

Leviticus 19:33-34 Instructor's Translation

When an **immigrant** lives with you in your land, do not mistreat him. The **immigrant** living with you must be treated as one of your native-born. **Love him as yourself**, for you were **immigrants** in Egypt. I am the Lord your God.

Exodus 23:4-5 Instructor's Translation

If you come across **your enemy's** ox or donkey wandering off, be sure to take it back to him. If you see the donkey of someone who hates you fallen down under its load, do not leave it there; be sure you **help him** with it.

These passages make it clear that Jesus' "love your enemy" is not a repudiation of Old Testament ethics. Rather, the Torah presented various perspectives on the call to love one's neighbor, and this generated a huge amount of debate within the Judaism of Jesus' day: Who counts as a neighbor? Whom am I obligated to love?

"And Hate Your Enemy"

Who is the enemy? Jesus likely has the words of David close at hand.

Psalms 139:21-22 Instructor's Translation

Do I not hate those who hate you, O Lord?

And do I not loathe those who rise up against you?

I hate them with the utmost hatred;

they have become my enemies.

Between Moses' and David's words to Israel and Jesus' day, Israel has had its rise and fall, and has been oppressed at the hands of non-Jewish empires for nearly 600 years: Babylon, Persia, Greece, Egypt, and now Rome.

Many Jews would feel hatred for these idolatrous empires as a patriotic duty. It was, of course, to be complemented by the communal loyalty expressed by Leviticus 19:18, but this love would not have to include one's oppressors.

We don't know if "hate your enemy" came from a known source that Jesus' hearers would be aware of, but there is little doubt that many would have taken this line as the natural pair to loving your Israelite neighbor.

1QRule of the Community 1:10-11: "All the sons of light are to hate all the sons of darkness, each according to its guilt at the time of God's vengeance."

Manual of Discipline (1Q). 1:10-11.

In Matthew 5:44, "I say love your enemies, pray for those who persecute you," Jesus makes the "enemy" a broad and open-ended reference.

"Love" here is the word *agapao*. The word refers to a chosen attitude and the resulting action, rather than primarily an emotion or feeling. Notice how "love" is paired with prayer and providing food and water in 5:44-45, and later greeting and hospitality in 5:47. These are "love" actions.

This love extends beyond simply non-retaliation (as in the previous teaching), but goes one step further, as Jesus says to actively seek the good of their persecutors. It's not just refraining from revenge or retaliation, but taking a positive action.

"Love your enemies was not advice for the Stoic who must remain even-tempered in the face of a fickle world. Nor is it prudent wisdom, to the effect that, just as it takes water, not fire, to put out a fire, so it takes love, not hate to overcome hate. Jesus does not promise that love will turn enemies into friends. He is instead calling for a love which does not depend on something else. Jesus' words go far beyond a call to give up vengeance and require positive action. In short, 'Love your enemies' seems to contain what may have been a novel demand: do good to the enemy, despite the circumstances and the results."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew 1-7 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 552.

"Love of enemies and renunciation of retaliation were joined together for Jesus. ... The demand to forgo retaliation is understood as an active behavior. ... The point lies in the voluntary doubling of the suffered wrong. By inviting the voluntary increase of wrong suffered, it places before one's eyes the order of violence and counter-violence that stands against the reign of God and simultaneously breaks through it symbolically ... it makes clear the absurdity of violence. Love of enemies thus consists in confronting the enemy with the order of the reign of God that is also an offer of salvation to him or her."

Schröter, Jens (2014). [*Jesus of Nazareth: Jew from Galilee, Savior of the World*](#). Baylor University Press. 144-145.

Jesus' love did not prevent him from verbally challenging and exposing his opponents ([ch. 23](#)); it's not simply being nice to people, but can motivate rebuke.

The motivation for loving enemies in [Matthew 5:45](#) reflects the character of the Father.

It will be the proper outworking of being in relationship with the Father of Jesus. People who do good or evil are both in God's good world, and he doesn't target his favorites in providing natural resources ([France, 226](#)). This should give us pause when we pray God's "discriminatory benevolence" to his people.

Notice how, after meditating on the wisdom of Torah, Jesus then turns to meditate on weather patterns and what rainfall teaches us about the character of God. This is classic wisdom mode ("Look at the ant, you lazy man!" [Proverbs 6](#)) of accumulating observations from all of life and bringing them to bear on the present.

In [Matthew 5:46-47](#), Jesus highlights that benevolence restricted to one's tribe is no more than what the rest of the world expects and practices.

- Note that "greet" and "love" are parallel: It is about an accepting welcome. Love welcomes others into one's life.
- Tax collectors, gentiles: traditional Jewish terms for those at the bottom of the moral scale. Everyone looks after their own.

"Be *Teleios*"

In [Matthew 5:48](#), Jesus says, "be *teleios*, just as your heavenly Father is *teleios*."

Jesus is forming a community of new humans, whose nature reflects that of their creator. Jesus looks behind the laws into the very heart and character of God.

The Greek word *teleios* has a range of meaning:

- “perfect” = without moral flaw (Jas. 3:2)
- “mature” = grown up (1 Cor. 14:20, “don’t be like children, in your thinking become *teleios*”; Eph. 4:13, “to become one *teleios* human”; Col. 1:28, “so that we can present everyone as *teleios* in the Messiah.”)
- “whole/complete” = to fulfill one’s purpose (Jas. 1:4; 1 John 4:18)

Matthew 19:21 NIV

Jesus answered, “If you want to be **teleios**, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven. Then come, follow me.”

James 1:4 NIV

Let perseverance finish its work so that you may be **teleios** and complete, not lacking anything.

The sentence structure of Jesus’ command is surely an allusion to, “you all shall be holy as I am holy” (Lev. 11:44, 45; 19:2; 20:7, 26).

“The use of *teleios* (perfect) instead of ‘holy’ ... is a wider term than moral flawlessness, and is used for spiritual ‘maturity,’ for example, in 1 Cor. 2:6; 14:20; Phil. 3:15 ... Matthew will use *teleios* again in 19:21 to denote the higher level of commitment represented by the rich man’s selling his possessions in contrast with his merely keeping the commandments (including again Lev. 19:18). It is thus a suitable term to sum up the “greater righteousness” of v. 20, a righteousness which is demanded not only from the spiritual elites but from all who belong to the kingdom of God. ... [Jesus invites us to] look behind the laws of the Torah to the mind and character of God himself. Whereas any definable set of rules could, in principle, be fully kept, the demand of the kingdom of heaven has no such limit—or rather its limit is perfection, the perfection of God himself.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew, The New International Commentary on the New Testament*](#). Eerdmans. 228.

Reflection Question

What does Jesus mean when he tells his followers to “be perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect” (Matt. 5:48)?